

laws acknowledged that Black Americans must be able to exercise basic rights, such as property ownership and use of the courts, though not without limitations.

Many Black people in the South became politically active on behalf of the Republican Party. Notable among them were former Union soldiers, prominent ministers, and teachers. They helped maintain Republican Party dominance in the South during the early Reconstruction period, and many were elected to public office, including, in 1870, Hiram Rhodes Revels from Mississippi, the first Black member of the Senate, and Joseph Rainey of South Carolina, the first Black member of the House of Representatives.